A COOPERATIVE CARD DEDUCTION GAME · PRISON DECK EDITION

ESCAPE FROM ACE-CATRAZ!

Everyone can see your cards. Except you.

2–4	52 + 18	CO-OP	0
PLAYERS	CARDS	WIN OR LOSE TOGETHER	PEEKS AT YOUR OWN HAND

OVERVIEW

You and your crew are inmates of the world's most notorious prison, **Ace-Catraz**. Four gangs run the cell blocks, and you can't escape alone.

Each player holds a hand of cards, with a twist: you hold them **facing outward**. Everyone else can see your cards. You can't. Rely on your crew to tell you what you're holding, and sneak past the guards together.

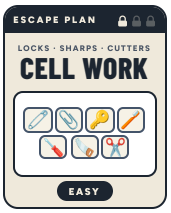
GOAL

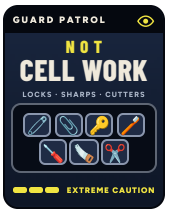
The crew wins by completing **the entire escape plan**: every obstacle cleared, with one card from every player each time.

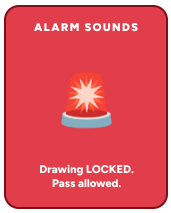
One wrong card trips the alarm and **everyone** goes back to their cells.

Every Prison card is **a gang and a tool**. Hints can be about either.

COMPONENTS









52 PRISON CARDS

52 Prison cards (4 gangs × 13 tools), **17 Security cards** (two-sided: obstacle / guard patrol) and **1 Alarm Sounds card**. No standard playing cards are needed.

THE FOUR GANGS



🔥 **Hotheads**
NORTH BLOCK



🍭 **Sticky Fingers**
NORTH BLOCK



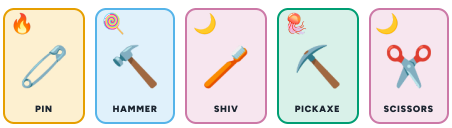
🌙 **Night Shift**
SOUTH BLOCK



🪼 **Jelly Crew**
SOUTH BLOCK

THE BIG TWIST: YOU CAN'T SEE YOUR OWN HAND

WHAT YOUR CREW SEES



↔

WHAT YOU SEE



Teammates give you hints (a gang or a tool) through Guard Checks. Keep track of what you've been told.

SECURITY CARDS & SET-UP

THE THREE KINDS OF SECURITY CARD



EASY × 6

One padlock. Matches about half the deck: a cell block, a work zone or quiet/loud.



MEDIUM × 6

Two padlocks. One whole gang, or a small group of tools such as the Heavy Hitters.



HARD × 5

Three padlocks. Only **two tools** match, such as the Smashers.

Each card is two-sided: the obstacle side is shown here, and the guard patrol side is on the back (see page 3). Three padlocks on the front means one alert bar on the back.

BEFORE YOU PLAY

1. **Build the Escape Plan.** Set the **HARD** cards and the Alarm card aside. Add **1** (2 players), **2** (3 players) or **3** (4 players) HARD cards to the Easy and Medium cards and shuffle. Deal them face down in a line in the centre: these are the **Obstacles**.
2. **Create the Patrol Deck.** Shuffle the unused HARD cards into the remaining Security cards, patrol side up on top. Place it next to the Flashlight Deck.
3. **Peek at the lock levels, then choose your escape path.** Look at the padlocks on the back of each Obstacle, then agree on a direction: **left-to-right** or **right-to-left**. Flip the first two Obstacles from that end face up. The first is the **active** Obstacle.
4. **Prepare the Flashlight Deck.** Shuffle the 52 Prison cards and place them face down on top of the Alarm Sounds card (a 53-card deck).
5. **Prep the crew.** Deal 5 cards to each player. **No peeking at your own cards.** Hold them facing outward.

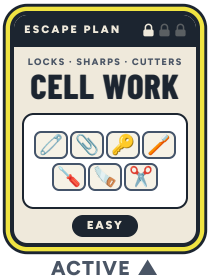
OBSTACLES BY PLAYER COUNT

PLAYERS	OBSTACLES	HARD ADDED
2	8	1
3	5	2
4	3	3

Tip: to raise the difficulty, add 1 extra Obstacle.

Why peek first? Seeing the lock levels lets the crew decide whether to take the tough locks early or save them for last.

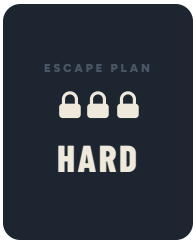
SET-UP FOR 4 PLAYERS



ACTIVE ▲



NEXT ▲



LOCKED ▲



PATROL DECK ▲



FLASHLIGHT DECK ▲

Each inmate holds five cards. Cards face outward, so everyone sees your hand but you.

ON YOUR TURN

1. Perform **one** of the five actions › **2.** Optionally attempt a **Breakthrough**

1 PLAY MY PART

Choose a card from your hand **without looking at it**. Place it face down on an **unoccupied corner of the active Obstacle**. Then draw a card from the Flashlight Deck into your hand, keeping it facing away from you.



2 PERFORM A GUARD CHECK

1. Flip the top **Patrol** card and the top **Flashlight** card.
2. Compare the Flashlight card against the Patrol card's **NOT** line.
3. **Fail:** the card **matches** what the patrol is NOT looking for. Stay silent. Your turn is over.
4. **Pass:** the card does **not** match. Point to a card in a teammate's hand and say either its **gang** or its **tool**.
5. Discard both revealed cards.



PASS ✔



Axe is loud, so it is not a Quiet Tool. **Pass.** Give a hint!

FAIL ✖



Safety Pin is a Quiet Tool. **Fail.** Say nothing.

READING THE PATROL CARD

The yellow bars show how risky the check is. **Extreme caution** (three bars, the card's obstacle side is Easy) is hard to pass because it rules out half the deck. **Relaxed** (one bar, the obstacle side is Hard) is easy to pass because it rules out only two tools. The top of the Patrol deck always shows how tough the next check is.

HINTS, IN PRACTICE

Point at a teammate's card and say its **gang** or its **tool**, never both. "**That one is a Jelly Crew**" or "**that one is a Handsaw**." Your teammate remembers it and builds a picture over several turns.



3 DISTRACT

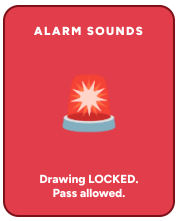
Discard **any** card at the active Obstacle, then choose a Patrol card from the discard pile and shuffle it back into the Patrol deck. Use it to remove a card you know is wrong, and to bring back an easy Guard Check.

4 RIOT

Discard **5 cards** from the top of the Flashlight Deck (it must have at least 5 left), then **swap any two cards**: your own, another player's, or one from the discard pile. At least one must be in a player's hand. The best way to move a card to where it's needed.

5 PASS

Only available once the **Alarm Sounds card is visible**, which means the Flashlight Deck has run out. Skip your turn. (Pass is also what you do if you have no other legal action.)
When the Alarm card shows, **drawing is locked**: planting a card no longer replaces it, so hands shrink as the crew plants.



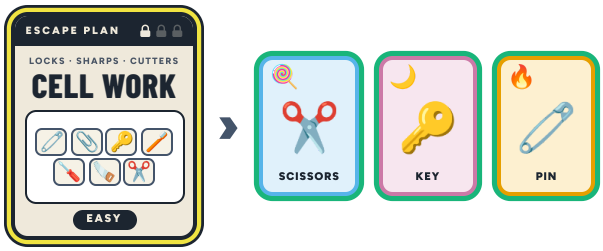
THEN, OPTIONALLY: BREAKTHROUGH

If **each player has planted exactly one card** on the active Obstacle, you may attempt a Breakthrough. Reveal every planted card.

All cards meet the condition → success! Stack the used cards face down on the Obstacle, reveal the next face-down Obstacle (so two are visible), and the next Obstacle in your direction becomes active.

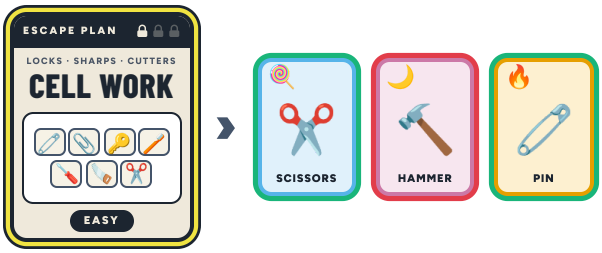
Even one card fails → the alarm is tripped and **everyone loses immediately**.

SUCCESS · 3 PLAYERS · OBSTACLE: CELL WORK



Scissors, Stolen Key and Safety Pin are all Cell Work tools. On to the next Obstacle!

ALARM! · 3 PLAYERS · OBSTACLE: CELL WORK



The Hammer is a Yard Work tool. Everyone loses. Safety first.

Safety first. Before attempting, make sure every planted card is one you're certain about. If any player is unsure of their own planted card, let a teammate who **is** certain make the call, or Distract it. If one planted card is certain to be right, **one verifier** is enough: everyone else's cards were seen while being planted.

END GAME & REMINDERS

FREEDOM!

If you have completed **all Obstacles** in the Escape Plan, you win. Enjoy your freedom!

BACK TO YOUR CELLS

If any **Breakthrough fails**, or **all players have no cards in hand** and Obstacles remain, you lose.

CRITICAL REMINDERS

- You see your teammates' hands; **you cannot see your own**.
- Once a card is planted face down, **no one can look at it again**.
- Inmates can only ever see the **active Obstacle and the next one**.
- You may only plant cards at the **active Obstacle**.
- Every Obstacle needs **exactly one card from each player** to pass.
- If any deck is empty, you **cannot reshuffle**.

QUICK REFERENCE: YOUR FIVE ACTIONS

ACTION	WHAT IT DOES	WHEN IT SHINES
Play my part	Plant a blind card face down, then draw	You know your card is right, or you want a fresh one
Guard check	Flip Patrol + Flashlight card; if you pass, give a hint	The crew needs information
Distract	Discard a planted card; return a Patrol card to the deck	A planted card is wrong or suspect
Riot	Discard 5 from the deck, swap any two cards	The card an Obstacle needs is in the wrong hand
Pass	Do nothing	Alarm visible and nothing useful to do

TIPS FOR THE CREW

- **Talk in hints, not answers.** A gang **or** a tool. Never both, never "that one's fine".
- **Track what you know.** Jot hints on a scorepad or count them on your fingers.
- **Watch every plant.** You need to remember every planted card to judge a Breakthrough.
- **Planting a mystery card can be smart.** A teammate can Distract it if it's wrong. Just don't call the Breakthrough on it yourself.
- **Pick your direction wisely.** Tackle hard locks while the deck is full, or clear easy ones first and keep hints flowing.
- **Mind the Flashlight Deck.** When it runs out, the Alarm appears and drawing is locked.

TOOL TRICKS

- Each tool belongs to a **category** (Lock Set, Sharps, Cutters, Climbing Gear, Smashers, Dig Set), a **zone** (Cell or Yard) and a **noise** (quiet or loud).
- A hint like "that's a **Handsaw**" tells your teammate its gang is still unknown, but it is Cutters, Cell Work and Loud.
- A hint like "that's a **Night Shift**" rules out every other gang, and every obstacle that needs a different one.
- Easy locks are broad. Hard locks name just two tools, so plan for them early.

CARD REFERENCE

EASY · ONE PADLOCK



MEDIUM · TWO PADLOCKS



HARD · THREE PADLOCKS



THE 13 TOOLS IN EVERY GANG

TOOL	CATEGORY	ZONE	NOISE	TOOL	CATEGORY	ZONE	NOISE
Safety Pin	Lock Set	CELL	QUIET	Rope	Climbing Gear	YARD	QUIET
Paperclip	Lock Set	CELL	QUIET	Scissors	Cutters	CELL	QUIET
Spoon	Dig Set	YARD	QUIET	Ladder	Climbing Gear	YARD	LOUD
Shiv	Sharps	CELL	QUIET	Axe	Smashers	YARD	LOUD
Screwdriver	Sharps	CELL	LOUD	Hammer	Smashers	YARD	LOUD
Stolen Key	Lock Set	CELL	LOUD	Pickaxe	Dig Set	YARD	LOUD
Handsaw	Cutters	CELL	LOUD				

HOW THE TESTS LINE UP

TEST	MATCHES	CARDS
North / South Block	The gangs of that cell block (Hotheads + Sticky Fingers, Night Shift + Jelly Crew)	26
Cell Work / Yard Work	Lock Set, Sharps, Cutters / Climbing Gear, Smashers, Dig Set	28 / 24
Quiet / Loud Tools	Tools that make no noise / tools that make a racket	24 / 28
One gang	All 13 tools in that gang	13
Heavy Hitters / Lock Set	Axe, Hammer, Pickaxe / Safety Pin, Paperclip, Stolen Key	12
Dig Set, Smashers, Climbing Gear, Cutters, Sharps	Exactly two tools each	8